

Week 1 Deliverables: Ideation & Problem Definition Framework

Topic: Making Tabletop Role-Playing Games (TRPGs like D&D) Easier and More Fun for Everyone
Market Focus: North American tabletop gaming community

Objective 1: Problem Definition

Tabletop role-playing games (TRPGs) — especially *Dungeons & Dragons* (D&D) — have grown fast in North America. Wizards of the Coast, the company behind D&D, says more than 50 million people worldwide have played the game at least once. Streaming shows like *Critical Role* and Netflix's *Stranger Things* have pulled in millions of new fans. Many of these fans are adults in their 20s, 30s, and 40s, not just teenagers.

But this growth has not solved three core problems:

1. **Too Hard for Beginners.** The main rulebook, the *Player's Handbook*, runs over 300 pages. New players must learn hundreds of rules, spells, and character choices before they even sit down to play. Official tools like D&D Beyond help with character building. But these tools have their own learning curve, and some content costs extra money to unlock.
2. **Too Much Work for Game Masters.** The person who runs the game is called the Dungeon Master (DM) in D&D, or the Game Master (GM) in most other TRPGs. Many DMs say they spend 3 to 5 hours preparing for a single 3-to-4-hour session. That means writing the story, drawing maps, and building non-player characters (NPCs). This heavy workload is a big reason why so few players want to run games. The hobby even has a name for this: the "GM shortage." People have talked about it for decades, though some experienced GMs think the problem gets overstated online.
3. **Hard to Find the Right Group.** Players want different things from the same game. Some want fast combat and loot — players like this get the joking nickname "murder hobos" in the community. Others want slow, emotional roleplay and character drama. Without a shared plan, groups fall apart. Many tables now hold a "Session Zero," a planning talk before the first game, to set expectations. But this habit is not universal, and even groups that do it can still drift apart over a long campaign.

Solving these problems will help new players join and stay. It will cut burnout for DMs and GMs. And it will help local game stores, libraries, and school clubs build stronger communities, both in person and online.

Objective 2: Target Audience Analysis (3 Stakeholder Groups)

Group 1: Novice Players (Beginners)

- **Who they are:** A wide mix of people. Some are teens who find the hobby through a school club. Many others are adults in their 20s, 30s, and 40s who got curious after watching *Critical Role*, *Dimension 20*, or *Stranger Things*. Today's new players are close to an even gender split. Community surveys put it at roughly 60% men and 40% women or non-binary players — a big shift from the hobby's older, mostly-male image.
- **Their role:** They are the new blood of the community. If their first few sessions go well, the hobby keeps growing. If they quit early, growth stalls.

Group 2: Dungeon Masters / Game Masters (DMs / GMs)

- Who they are: Often experienced players who love storytelling and world-building. But just as often, they are players who got pushed into the DM role because no one else in their group would do it.
- Their role: They are the hosts and organizers. Without a DM, a group cannot play. Willing DMs are hard to find, so keeping current DMs from burning out matters more than most players realize. If one DM quits, the whole group's games can end.

Group 3: Game Store Owners, Library Programs & Club Organizers

- Who they are: People who run local hobby shops — often called an "FLGS," short for "friendly local game store," in the community. This group also includes public library teen-program staff and campus tabletop club leaders.
 - Their role: They provide the physical tables, spaces, and events where people play face-to-face. They now compete with online options too: Discord servers, "looking for group" (LFG) posts on Reddit, virtual tabletop apps like Roll20 and Foundry VTT, and paid GM-for-hire sites. These options make it easier than ever to find a game without leaving home.
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Objective 3: Pain Points & Impact Breakdown

1. Impact on Novice Players (Group 1)

- Rule Overload & Anxiety: Beginners feel overwhelmed by 300-plus-page rulebooks and dozens of character options. They worry about making mistakes in front of the group.
- Trouble Finding Friendly Groups: It is hard for a beginner to find a patient group willing to teach the rules step by step, especially outside big cities.
- Quitting Early: A confusing or unfriendly first session usually ends a beginner's interest in TRPGs for good. First impressions are very hard to undo.

2. Impact on Dungeon Masters (Group 2)

- Spending Too Much Time Preparing: Many DMs spend 3 to 5 hours preparing for one game session — writing plot, building NPCs, and drawing maps. Over a long campaign, this adds up to real burnout.
- Constantly Pausing to Explain Rules: Stopping the story every few minutes to explain a rule breaks the mood and drains the DM's energy.
- Mismatched Expectations: Sometimes players want silly, combat-heavy fun, but the DM prepared a serious drama — or the other way around. This creates real conflict. Even a Session Zero cannot always stop expectations from drifting apart over time.

3. Impact on Game Stores, Libraries & Club Organizers (Group 3)

- Low Revenue for Long Table Use: A TRPG group can sit at one table for 4 to 6 hours while buying only a drink or two. Small stores often run on thin profit margins, sometimes just 5% to 12% after rent and staff costs. That math is hard on a small business.
 - Relying Too Much on One DM: If the main DM moves away or quits, the whole group often disappears. So does that store's regular business.
 - Low Retention Rate: So many beginners drop out early that stores and clubs struggle to build a steady, returning player base. Every early dropout is a customer they likely will not get back.
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Sources

- [D&D Beyond's 2026 Development Roadmap](#) — Wizards of the Coast
- ["It's Not Just You: NYC Has a Serious Dungeon Master Shortage"](#) — Hell Gate
- [D&D Player Demographics](#) — Games Learning Society
- [Tabletop Role Playing Game Market Report](#) — Fortune Business Insights